the Indian population. The top 25 per cent of households, for instance, corner 50 per cent of the domestic remittance intake, as a result of which remittances lead to greater consumption inequality.[18] Nowhere is this more evident than in Kerala, which is one of the most unequal states of India in terms of consumption expenditure. The Gulf outside Kerala has led to a gulf within, despite long political rule by communist ideals. But because efforts to improve education and healthcare in Kerala have far exceeded those in Bihar, its return on migration in the long run has been more substantive. The migratory path from rags to riches in India, therefore, depends on the duration of stay and investment in education.

Caste Away

The potential of migration to narrow down social inequalities is clearest in the case of caste. Untouchability is impossible to entertain in a jam-packed Mumbai local train, and notions of caste purity are watered down in dense urban settlements. This does not mean that caste has no role to play in migration as job recruitment in India is strongly mediated through caste- or region-based social networks.[19] Nor does it mean that caste-based residential segregation does not exist in urban centres. But compared to rural settings, the freedom to try out different jobs and live in different places is substantially enhanced.

The historical evidence on migration as a means to escape caste oppression is also overwhelming, as witnessed in the earlier account of the Great Indian Migration Wave and Ambedkar's numerous exhortations. In her work on land and caste in south India, economic historian Dharma Kumar noted the possibilities opened up by emigration in the 19th century for social mobility including 'greater knowledge of agricultural techniques and less willingness to abide by caste restrictions'.[20] Similarly, the Census of 1931 observed that emigration from southern India was 'a great teacher of self-respect' and had 'contributed most to the growth of consciousness among the depressed classes'.[21] Several personal memoirs such as Narendra Jadhav's *Untouchables* or Daya Pawar's *Baluta* or Sujatha Gidla's *Ants*